

30 Minutes Expert

Tag me if you can

Don't know the name of the artiste serenading you? Time to get your MP3 tags in place!

You may have an awfully huge collection of MP3s on your computer, and a majority of them may not be correctly identifiable. Whilst copying MP3s or ripping an audio CD, seldom does anyone bother to fill in information such as the artist name, song title, year, genre, etc, into the MP3 file. And if you don't fill in this info, called MP3 metadata, or tags,

album fields. Right-click a file, and in the menu that pops up, click 'edit' to edit the tag. A window pops up wherein the 'General' tab displays song duration, bitrate, copyright protection, etc. Enter the title of the song, name of the artist, album name, year of release and genre in this window. Add the song's lyrics into the MP3 file by clicking on the Lyrics tab. Click on Save when you're done.

A cool feature supported is the latest ID3v2 tag system, which allows you to specify an image file to be integrated into an MP3 file. Thus, you can scan and resize the album cover and copy it into all the songs ripped from that album. Click on 'Find art file' within the 'General' tab, and browse to the image file. Click Open and then Save. The mp3 file is embedded with that particular image file. The size of the mp3 file size increases by the size of

the image file, of course. Also, those players unable to read ID3v2 tags will not be able to read the embedded image file, but will play the MP3. Click on save to save this information.

Next, in the 'Rename' tab, after selecting the files of your choice, click Rename, and all the selected MP3 files are renamed using the default naming convention—'Artist name - Title'. Customise the filename format by changing the File name mask, using the ID3 identification mask list to the right of this field. For example,

change the mask to '%2 - %1 - %3 - %4' to rename files in the following format—'Title - Artist name - Album name - Year.'

Tick 'Replace underscores with spaces' if your MP3 files tags contain them. You can also change the case of the filenames to be generated. You can have the entire file name in capital letters or small caps. Alternatively, you may capitalise the first letter of each word or just the first word only.

Select a group of files in the multiple file tag editor, and fill in the information in the fields labelled artist, album, year, genre and click on Save Tags. This will fill in all the tags in the selected mp3 files.

For those unfortunates who have no idea which MP3 is the creation of which artist, there's a software known as MoodLogic (www.moodlogic.com). After installation, it asks for a login name for your account and a password. Registration is free. MoodLogic scans and saves all MP3s on your hard disk to its playlist. It then connects to the MoodLogic server and automatically updates the MP3 tags. The trial version allows you to update a limited number of MP3 files. You can sign up for unlimited access.

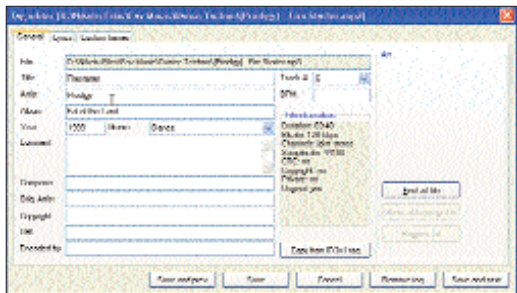
To update an MP3 tag, click on **Tools > Fix ID3 tags** and file names. A window showing the number of MP3s it can update pops up. Click on Continue. The window lists all the available information it can provide and update. Select the check box Fix file names and Fix ID3 tags to update the ID3 tag information and also the filename of the file to artist name - song title. Next, click on Fix All to complete the automatic updating of the selected files.

A plug-in also lets you use MoodLogic from within Winamp.

So, go tag your mp3 files all nice and proper, like you always wanted to, and stop nonsense such as 'Song%2025.d333' scrolling across Winamp when you're playing a song for the first time! ■

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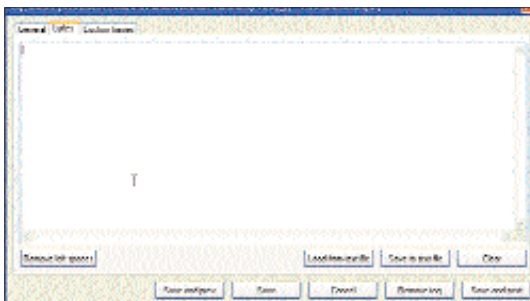
Edit the tag information along with adding a small image to the MP3 file

you won't be able to use the tag-searching feature of some MP3 players, which support playlist searches by searching on tag information.

One of the many utilities that help you fill in tags is Tag & Rename 3.0.6. Use it to edit the tag as you play the file in your default mp3 player. Of course, many players such as Winamp have a feature built-in by which you can fill in the tag, such software make it easier.

After installing, start the application and take a look at the tabs in the open window. When you select your MP3 folder from the pane at the bottom, the first allows you to rename and tag a single file. The second one does a batch job of renaming and tagging a group of MP3 files ripped from an album.

Click on the first tab. Tag & Rename lists the files in the right-hand pane with or without tag information. It shows a column view of the MP3 files with the file name, title, artist name and



Add the lyrics too into the MP3 file itself